

heavenly bodies. All these computations required billions of calculations, taking hundreds of factors into account, and were not possible using other computers of that era.

1955

User Groups

January: Fully transistorised

The TRADIC (TRANsistor DIgital Computer) was the first fully-transistorised computer; it was built by Bell Labs for the US Air Force. It had 700 transistors and 10,000 germanium diodes. A small and light system, TRADIC was installed on a B-52 Stratofortress bomber and consumed only 100 watts, a far cry from its giant vacuum tube contemporaries. It was also comparable in speed, performing about a million logical operations in one second.

August: SHARE, a user group that's still around

SHARE, the oldest and still-functioning computer user group was founded by the aerospace industry users of IBM mainframes. User groups, formed initially to share information about software and best uses, later morphed into what is known as communities. User groups—Linux User Groups, for example—have been the driving force in the implementation and adoption of new technologies.

1956

Disk Storage

January: The Stretch—all about speed

The Stretch project, which eventually became IBM 7030—a second generation mainframe computer—was started. The aim of the project was to build a computer a hundred times faster than the 704, though actual performance was only 30x. It was a transistorised supercomputer intended for use by scientists. Construction began in 1959, and the first computer was delivered in 1961, a year behind schedule. Though the Stretch was not very successful